Goal: Solve optimization problems involving cost, revenue, and profit.

Cost Functions

Factoring in costs can be incorporated in a variety of ways. For example, it could act as an objective function:

Example 1. If the cost of fencing material is \$55/ft, what is the minimum cost to produce an enclosed space with an area of 490 000ft^2.

Example 2. Jessica wants to make a box such that:

(i) The volume is 144ft^3;

(ii) The length is double the width;

(iii) The top and bottom are made out of metal;

(iv) The sides are made out of wood.

If the cost of wood is $\$10/\text{ft}^2$ and the cost of metal is $\$20/\text{ft}^2$, what should the dimensions be to make the box as cheaply as possible?

Costs can also act as a constraint:

Example 3. Using the same setup as **Example 2.**, what is the largest box we can make if we have a budget of $240?

Revenue and Profit

Revenue: The total money earned. In symbols,

Example 4. A company's marketing department says that the number of units sold starts at 720, then decreases by 15 for every dollar increase in price.

(a) What should the price be to maximize revenue?

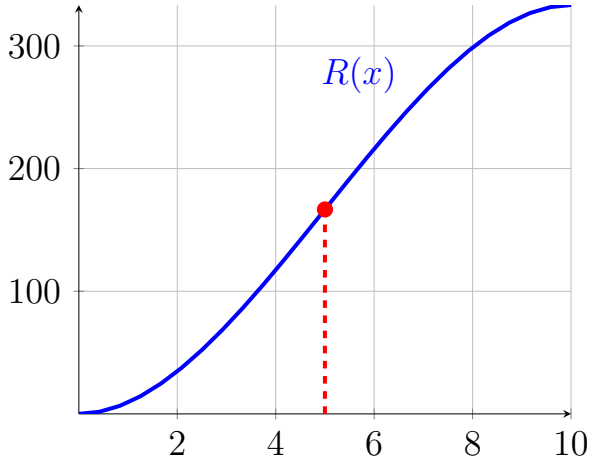
Profit: The total money earned after dealing with costs. In symbols,

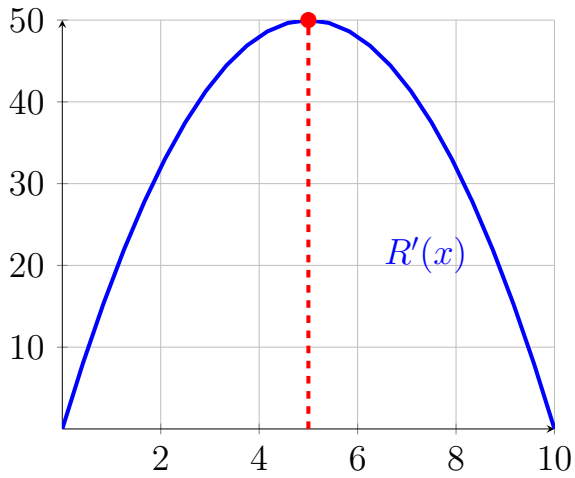
(b) What should the price be to maximize profit?

NOTE: The remainder of this section is NON-EXAMINABLE.

The Point of Diminishing Returns

Definition. When the marginal cost/revenue/profit obtains an absolute maximum, this is called the **point of diminishing returns**.





Example 5. A company uses the following function:

$$R(x) = 10x^2 - \frac{2}{3}x^3; \quad 0 \leq x \leq 10$$

to model revenue after spending x million dollars on advertising. Find and interpret the point of diminishing returns.